CHAPTER 6

JOINING THE CLUB

Feeling as though I belonged in the Proteas team was never going to be enough.

The experience of being selected to play for South Africa and scoring a century in the last Test of my first home series was fantastic, but I worked hard to see this event – albeit the realisation of a boyhood dream – not as the end of anything but as the beginning of a new and even greater challenge.

That's the nature of sport: you work hard to climb the mountain, eyes fixed resolutely on the peak, and then, just when you think you've reached the top, another higher peak comes into view and there's no option but to keep working and continue climbing ... and if and when you scale that peak, another peak appears. There's always another peak, always another challenge. The job is never done.

It soon became clear to me that I would have to work hard to keep my place in the side. For a 20-year-old youngster joining a consistently successful team, driven by a core group of outstanding and established players, absolutely nothing could be taken for granted, and the Proteas continued to thrive.

During the 26 months between my first series at home against England in December 2004 and the ICC Cricket World Cup held in the Caribbean in March 2007, the South African national team won no fewer than seven